

Eliciting consumer engagement, experience, and value co-creation to foster consumer-based-brand-equity in service context: Moderation of perceived-health-beliefs

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Funding: This research did not receive any specific grant from funding agencies in the public, commercial, or not-for-profit sectors.

Conflict of interest: None.

Acknowledgments: None.

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Abstract

Although *consumer-brand-engagement* (CBE) and *consumer-brand-experience* (CBX) are identified as important research priorities, empirically-based insights regarding their relationship with tourism-consumers' resulting consumer-value cocreation (CVC), emotional-attachment and consumer-based-brand-equity (CBBE) remains scant, particularly during COVID-19 pandemic. In responding to this research gap, following Service-Dominant-Logic and Protection-Motivation-informed theories, we propose and test a model that explores the influence of CBE and CVC on CBX, which consequently effects emotional-attachment and CBBE with tourism service-brands. To explore such issues, we recruit a sample of 318 customers by using PLS-SEM. PLS-SEM-results indicate that CBE has a positive impact on CVC and CBX. Second, findings reveal CBX's positive influence on emotional-attachment and CBBE. Third, results corroborated the CBE's and CVC's indirect effect on emotional-attachment and CBBE, as mediated through CBX. Finally, findings illustrated a negative moderating influence of perceived-severity and positive moderating effect of self-efficacy among projected associations. We offer significant theoretical/managerial implications that develop from this study.

Keywords: Consumer brand engagement; consumer value co-creation; consumer brand experience; consumer-based brand equity; perceived severity; service context.

激发消费者参与、体验和价值共同创造，在服务环境中促进以消费者为基础的品牌公平
：适度感知健康信念

摘要

虽然消费者品牌参与（CBE）和消费者品牌体验（CBX）被认为是重要的研究重点，但基于经验的关于它们与旅游消费者产生的消费者价值协同（CVC），情感依恋和消费者品牌资产（CBBE）的关系的见解仍然很少，特别是在COVID-19大流行期间。

为了回应这一研究差距，我们提出并测试了一个模型，探讨了CBE和CVC对CBX的影响，从而影响了情感依恋和CBBE与旅游服务品牌的影响。为了探讨这些问题,我们使用PLS-SEM招募了318个客户的样本。PLS-SEM-结果表明CBE对CVC和CBX具有积极影响。其次，研究结果揭示了CBX对情绪依恋和CBBE的积极影响。第三，结果证实了CBE和CVC通过CBX介导的对情绪依恋和CBBE的间接影响。最后，研究结果表明，在预测的关联中，感知严重程度的负面调节影响和自我效能感的积极调节作用。我们提供了从这项研究中发展起来的重要理论/管理含义。

关键词：消费者品牌参与；消费者价值共同创造；消费者品牌体验；基于消费者的品牌资产；感知严重性；服务环境。

Introduction

Service industries, involving tourism destinations/sites are still confronting substantial challenges in view of global COVID-19 pandemic (UNWTO, 2022). It is due to pandemic, consumer's engagement, experience, behaviour, and/or attitudes have altered with how services are delivered and designed during and/or after-pandemic (Cambra-Fierro et al., 2022b; Miao et al., 2022; Prentice et al., 2021). In this context, the related and key issues of consumer engagement, experience and value co-creation have been constantly the consideration and attention of scholars in the service marketing and tourism fields (Kumar, Panda, & Adhikari, 2022; Kumar et al., 2019; Rather et al., 2019). Specifically, consumer brand engagement (CBE), as part of consumer engagement, plays a critical role in the tourism and/or service marketing literature (Addo et al., 2021; Flavián et al., 2020; Hollebeek et al., 2014; Kabadayi, Aksoy, & Turkay, 2022; Rather et al., 2021). Thus, this research is inspired by the increasing significance on both the practical suggestions of *Marketing Science Institute* (2020), to conduct further research on this subject, and the academic field (see also, Hollebeek et al., 2021a; Lim et al., 2021). For example, Algharabat et al. (2020) investigated the importance of consumer's participation and involvement on CBE, which in turn affects brand equity among mobile-phone service providers. Algharabat et al. (2020) claim that understanding of CBE is at an initial stage and thereby more research is needed in different nomological network models and different cultural contexts (Park & Gong, 2023; Shoukat & Ramkissoon, 2022).

Second, while, in conceptual study Shoukat and Ramkissoon (2022) argue that customer engagement is useful in generating customer experience and revisit intent with the hospitality industry, concerned visitors in outbreak may be mostly propelled by safety problems (Huang & Jahromi, 2021). As one more example, Kabadayi et al. (2022) understand the role of customer/brand love in steering consumer engagement/experience towards restaurant brands, which, during the pandemic might be superseded (balanced) through variables encompassing the tourism/destination brand's perceived-severity, self-efficacy, or protection. That is, during such COVID-19-crises, customer engagement and behaviour has been anticipated to reveal different or typical dynamics (like, by displaying high perceived-severity/risk; Han et al., 2022; Zheng et al., 2021), thereby, expected to challenge several insights documented in research within regular market contexts or (pre-pandemic) times, and warranting more exploration.

Third, in tourism service brand contexts, Chen et al. (2021) and Harrigan et al. (2019) argued that CBE is a contemporary topic, and additional exploration is needed owing to its substantial role in strategic brand decision making (Pansari & Kumar, 2017; So et al., 2020b). Recently, Kumar et al. (2022) and Wongsansukcharoen (2021) asserts that, CBE in tourism is still un-explored, and consequently warrants more investigation, particularly during pandemic-induced situations and contexts (Miao et al., 2022; Rather, 2021). Existing literature in the pandemic-induced tourism industry leads to remark that it has never been tested the effects of CBE and consumer value co-creation (CVC) on consumer brand experience (CBX), which consequently effects (post)-consumption behaviors (i.e., emotional attachment/EA, and consumer-based brand equity/CBBE in pandemic. Further, though few scholars have explored the impact of CBE on various marketing variables including social interactivity or loyalty (Addo et al., 2021; Kumar et al., 2022; Rather et al., 2019), brand associations, awareness and perceived quality (Algharabat et al., 2020) customer brand relationships (Hollebeek et al., 2014), satisfaction/trust (Rather et al., 2018; So et al., 2020a), limited agreement exists regarding the tourism-based CBE's effect on CVC and CBX in fostering consumer's emotional attachment and CBBE *during* (vs. *pre-*) COVID-19 pandemic, as explored here. Moreover, this research would contribute a value by determining and testing the key consequences of CBE in a developing country, wherein no study have tested such related issues in pandemic times. Thus, by investigating the dynamics and consequences of CBE in pandemic, we anticipate this study would provide strategic, novel insights.

Fourth, consumer brand experience and CBBE have disseminated in marketing research and practice (Algharabat et al., 2020; Bianchi et al., 2014; Lemon & Verhoef, 2017; Rather et al., 2021). CBX and CBBE have been argued to encourage better firm performance and consumer's lifetime value, informing top managerial preferences (Aaker, 1991; Arici et al., 2022; Homburg et al., 2016). Though, debate surrounds CBX's conceptualisation pertaining to interrelated-marketing variables (like CBE/CBBE; Iglesias et al., 2020; Lemon and Verhoef, 2017), and measurement (Brakus et al., 2009; Cambra-Fierro et al., 2022a). Taking into account, Taheri et al. (2019) and Lemon and Verhoef (2017, p. 85) admit the call for "to explore how existing marketing factors, like consumer brand engagement [or] equity ... relate to consumer experience," as examined in pandemic (tourism)-service context (Huang & Jahromi, 2021; Li et al., 2022).

Fifth, despite the extensive set of literature concerning perceived health/pandemic linked crises employing diverse theories or empirical contexts (Cambra-Fierro et al., 2022b; Ren et al., 2022), the impediment of COVID-19 pandemic affirms to revisit pandemic response strategies (Itani & Hollebeek, 2021; Prentice et al., 2021). Pandemic/health beliefs like protection motivation theory (PMT)-based threat (e.g., perceived-severity) and coping- (e.g., self-efficacy) appraisal halt tourist-destinations in many nations (Zheng et al., 2021). The distressing pandemic impacts also need destination (tourism) managers to re-design the health beliefs, CBE, CBX and CBBE, which are known as the fundamental facets of tourism and service industries, or service brands (Hollebeek et al., 2021b; Miao et al., 2022) *during* (vs. *pre*) pandemic.

In responding the aforementioned research gaps, the present study generates following key contributions to service marketing and tourism literature. First, as noted earlier, regardless of the growing insights of CBE/CBX in marketing (Islam et al., 2019; Kumar et al., 2022; So et al., 2020a), limited remains known concerning the effect of tourism-based CBE on CBX and CVC *during* (vs. *pre*) pandemic (Hollebeek et al., 2021b; Miao et al., 2022; Shoukat & Ramkissoon, 2022). Investigating the effect of CBE on CBX and CVC is important, as prior service/tourism-induced research has hardly considered such factors in isolation, analysis of these relations lags behind, thus, warranting additional research *during* (vs. *pre*-) pandemic tourism service brands.

Second, this study identifies tourism-induced CBX to have positive influence on the improvement of emotional attachment and CBBE, underscoring CBX's crucial role during the outbreak to deal with tourism/destination brands. Third, this study determines CBX's key mediating role in effecting the links between CBE/EA, CBE/CBBE, CVC/EA and CVC/CBBE in pandemic, thus broadening Algharabat et al. (2020), Kumar et al. (2022), Omar et al. (2022) and Rather et al. (2021). Fourth, this study further explores the moderating roles of health/pandemic-related beliefs (self-efficacy and perceived-severity) on associations relating CBX/emotional attachment, and CBX/CBBE, revealing a specific key managerial insight.

Thus, this research adds to promising area of tourism/destination branding by addressing the key gaps in existing research with reference to Indian destinations/sites. It is important as tourism industry augments a leading contribution to GDP in this region (Rather, 2017, 2020). The present research was performed at ending 2021. During the December/January months due to the festive excitement of New Year and Christmas celebrations, the destinations/sites

witnessed the highest-ever visitors (Financial Express, 2022). To estimate the research hypotheses, we adopted PLS-SEM on a sample of 318 visitors. Finally, following PLS-SEM-based results, tourist-destination managers and marketers can increase emotional attachment and CBBE to attract tourist flows through activities, which encourage the CBE, CBX and value co-creation, thereby spawning imperative *managerial implications* with tourism service brands.

Theoretical background and hypotheses development

Service dominant logic perspective

In tourism and marketing literature, unlike goods-dominant logic (GDL), service dominant logic (SDL)-informed lens is considered as an underlying research perspective, which proposes a service-driven comprehension of exchange (Park & Vargo, 2013). Vargo and Lusch (2004, p. 2) propose central propositions of SDL-perspective as, ‘intangibility, exchange processes, and relationships are central’ which are especially applicable in tourism/destination marketing (Blazquez-Resino et al., 2016). In tourism environment, SDL provides a crucial significance to process of (value)-creation that include the consumer as a (co)-creator of value and/or direct stakeholder (Font et al., 2021). Tourism/destination ecosystem is rooted in tourist’s experience, suggesting that destination providers/brands and tourists interact strongly at each phase of their relationship/s (Shoukat & Ramkissoon, 2022). The transformation to tourism-products/services based on customer experiences, related to Pine and Gilmore’s (1999) concept of experience economy.

The particular perspective realizes the active/dynamic participation (engagement) of consumers in improvement of their individual-based experience, where value has been shaped while interacting with destination/tourism brands’ resources (Font et al., 2021; Blazquez-Resino et al., 2016). This perspective emphasizes consumer-brand relationship due to dialog and interaction (Shaw et al., 2011). Against this background, SDL presents a theoretical framework that would help destination brands/firms to build a cutthroat benefit and to identify how the tourist is becoming fundamental in the development of destination brand in increasing value-cocreation, experience, and consequent brand equity (Rihova et al., 2018).

Effect of consumer-brand-engagement on consumer brand experience

SDL-informed CBE is defined as the degree of emotional (passion), cognitive (knowledge), and behavioral (activation) investment into specific brand interactions/connections (Hollebeek et al., 2019b). Pansari & Kumar (2017) refer CBE as a mechanics of consumer's value addition towards brand/firm, either due to direct or indirect contributions. In tourism-marketing literature, adoption of strategic-CBX focus is broadly encouraged (Chen et al., 2021; Hao, 2020; Rather & Hollebeek, 2021; So et al., 2020a, b). CBX is consumer's perception of emotional, sensory, and cognitive consequences of interactions towards the service brands/firms (Barnes et al., 2014; Kumar et al., 2022; Rather et al., 2021). The consumer is intellectually, emotionally, physically and spiritually involved by influential elements (Brakus et al., 2009; Homburg et al., 2016).

Consumer brand experience includes consumers' entire purchase journey encompassing pre, intra, and/or post- purchase phases (Arici et al., 2022; Lemon & Verhoef, 2017; Jaziri & Rather, 2022). While comparing the scope of CBE, which is limited to client's (intra)-interaction-based dynamics, existing research including Hollebeek et al. (2014) arguing CBE as a driver of CBX (see also, Khan et al., 2019). Moreover, Shoukat and Ramkissoon (2022) in their conceptual study proposed that consumer's (intra)-interaction engagement increases their (trans)-interaction experiences as it progresses alongside CBX-journey (Khan et al., 2022). For that reason, excessive and frequent-interactions, CBE's (intra)-interaction strengthens clients brand experience journey; Jeong & Shin, 2020; Rather & Ramkissoon, 2023). In other words, CBX cannot be optimized until tourism-destination-related CBE is evaluated, thus we posit:

H1: CBE positively affects CBX towards a tourist destination.

Effect of consumer brand engagement on consumer value co-creation

The CBE concept is considered in order that customer attitudes/behavior outside the purchase can affect brands/firms (Hollebeek et al., 2019b; Kumar et al., 2022). Tourism practitioners are also fascinated in the likelihood of engaging consumers or (visitors) in the co-creation with the purpose of to elicit consumer value (e.g., Nangpiire et al., 2022; Woratschek, Horbel, & Popp, 2020). The SDL proposes that tourism suppliers jointly generate value by service exchange process while interacting with the tourists (Park & Vargo, 2013) that is especially applicable in destination (tourism) marketing environment (Shaw et al., 2011). The tourism is typically rooted

into consumers' experience, denoting that consumers and service providers immensely interact at each phase of the relationship (Rasoolimanesh et al., 2021; Font et al., 2021).

In relation to SDL-informed perspective (Font et al., 2021; Park & Vargo, 2013; Rather, 2023), value might be co-created in collaboration- with a consumer instead surrounded by the brand/firm; thereby consumer-focused brands are advised to involve consumers in value co-creation (Hollebeek & Rather, 2019; Woratschek et al., 2020). Consumers are involved and can be developed as direct-stakeholders in value cocreation (Shaw et al., 2011; Vargo & Lusch, 2016). As CBE elicits in the long run, consumers are expected to reveal their individual information (experience) with others (Font et al., 2021; Grisseman & Stokburger-Sauer, 2013). Though, the importance of CBE/CVC has been previously linked in diverse marketing and service contexts (Assiouras et al., 2019; Yen et al., 2021), the influence of destination-based CBE on consumer value co-creation have yet to be investigated, specifically in tourism brand setting. For instance, while, Jaakkola and Alexander (2014) studied CBE's influence in developing CVC in healthcare service setting, France et al. (2018) corroborated that CBE as an important variable in persuading consumer brand co-creation behavior. Correspondingly, Yen et al. (2021) checked the influence of consumer's engagement on value-cocreation behaviors within restaurant industry. While consumer brand engagement and consumer value cocreation have been formerly linked, as outlined (e.g., Assiouras et al., 2019; Yen et al., 2021), insight of this in tourism during pandemic based relationship is yet evolving with other behavioral variables (including CBX, emotional attachment), thus we posit:

H2: CBE positively affects consumer value co-creation towards a tourist destination.

Impact of consumer value co-creation on consumer brand experience

The notion of consumer co-creation of value results from service dominant logic perspective, as noted (Vargo & Lusch, 2016). SDL-based consumer value co-creation is defined as their perceived-value occurs through collaboration, interaction and customized actions with stakeholder/organization (Rihova et al., 2018). SDL-informed co-creation concept is rooted on customer as a value creator and collaborating (interacting) with firms/brands to co-create value (e.g., Grisseman & Stokburger-Sauer, 2013; Prebensen & Xie, 2018). Organizations/brands can use the value cocreation concept as one of the tactics to sustain valuable consumers (Rihova et

al., 2018). Existing research revealed that (online)-cocreation deepens the impact of consumer's experience, also promotes purchase intent and behavior with the brand (Anshu et al., 2022), thus, supports excellent CBX-journey (Sugathan & Ranjan, 2019). Hence offering pleasant/positive consumer's experience *via* value cocreation might assist the brands/providers to retain, attract, and build consumers part of their business (Anshu et al., 2022).

Tourism is turning out to be more interactive and complex owing to the amalgamation of multiple touch-points (e.g., destination-brand, where visitor is visiting) facilitating customers to connect with a brand via differing media/channels, especially earlier to consumption-journey (Lemon & Verhoef 2017). CVC might develop the CBX-journey (Shaw et al., 2011), and the interaction/collaboration resulting from the value co-creation offers actual-experience (Prebensen & Xie, 2018). CVC acts as a combining linkage between tourism context and service suppliers (Blazquez-Resino et al., 2016). Therefore, destination providers need to encourage tourists into value (co)creating processes by providing resources to construct consumer experience journey over time; Assiouras et al., 2019). Further, if the consumer has robust values, which affiliate with tourism-destination/attraction, relationship would be the determined, and the CBX journey would be reinforced. Hence, we hypothesize that:

H3: Consumer value co-creation positively influences CBX with a tourist destination.

Customer experience's effect on emotional attachment

With regard to attachment theory within psychology, attachment is believed to be an emotional connection/bond between a person and a target object/brand (Bowlby, 1979). Further, the object, which elicits these feelings could be a destination, place, or brand (Barreda et al., 2020), like a tourism/destination brand. Based on attachment theory, emotional attachment is defined as a psychological bond between an individual and a brand, typified by profound feelings of affection-, connection-, and passion (Grisaffe & Nguyen, 2011). In other words, it includes the affective elements of the brand, like deep feelings of connection, affection, love or passion (Hang et al., 2020). Customers articulating positive emotional attachments can be employed as a substitute measure for marketers in measuring crisis management success (Wang et al., 2021). Customers usually articulate their emotions in major crisis at their loved attractions/destination to reveal their closeness, support, and to assist its recovery (Zheng et al., 2021).

To attain emotional attachment, tourism managers should recognize emotional bonding antecedents towards the brands/service offerings (Liu et al., 2020). Published literature on CBX (e.g., Verhoef et al., 2009) denoted that consumer experience is personal, which involves their emotions, thinking, feelings, or senses. This involvement relating to CBX stimulates the customer's bond (attachment) with a destination (Barreda et al., 2020). Such bonds (attachments) persist throughout the entire consumers purchase journey as soon as they develop emotional connections with other customers, destinations, or brands (e.g., Hussain et al., 2020). Thus, we anticipate:

H4: CBX positively influences emotional attachment with a tourism destination.

Consumer brand experience's effect on consumer-based brand equity

Brand equity is one of the most vital factors in brand management field from managerial as well as academic viewpoints (Bianchi et al., 2014; Iglesias et al., 2020; Omar et al., 2022; Yang et al., 2016). Within tourism market/industry, destination-brand has been used as a communication tool to increase the performance of a tourist-destination (Rahman et al., 2020). The destination brand strategy can lead destination-based brand equity development; a notion that could elucidate the overall value generated into visitors minds (Sürücü et al., 2019). Various researchers conceptualise brand-equity as a relational- and market-led asset created through relationships and interactions between brands and their consumers (Iglesias et al., 2020; Sürücü et al., 2019). Destination marketers continually seek to measure and understand brand-based effectiveness through CBBE concept of Aaker (1991) and Keller (1993). Over the last decade, CBBE concept developed by Aaker (1991) and Keller (2003) has received raising interest from tourism scholars, as a way to assess the effectiveness of branding (Bianchi et al., 2014). In accordance with Pike (2010), CBBE is defined as the understanding of how marketing initiatives impact customers' learning and re-calling of brand information due to a specific symbol or sign developed by a firm/brand (see also, Bianchi et al., 2014).

The association between CBX and brand equity is investigated in the service sector, for example Iglesias et al. (2020) offer an empirical support for a positive impact of customer's sensory brand experience on brand equity in banking industry. In the hotel industry Sürücü et al. (2019) finds that, brand image, brand awareness and physical quality are the important building

blocks to CBBE. Yang et al. (2016) indicates that destination service performance and word of mouth has a significant effect on destination-brand equity in mainland Chinese outbound visitors. In tourism heritage destination brand context, Rahman et al. (2020) explored the role of tourist's heritage brand experience and heritage destination loyalty on the development of CBBE. We argue that experience marketing theory (Brakus et al., 2009) is a suitable theoretical lens to examine consumer-based brand equity. Consumer brand experience is improvable and controllable to some extent and consumers' service experiences play a key role in developing competitive advantage and brand loyalty (Algharabat et al., 2020; Meyer & Schwager, 2007) or brand formation (e.g., Berry, 2000). CBBE is specifically significant for tourist-destinations, as different consumers have diverse perceptions regarding the same attraction/destination. Thus, it is crucial to identify, how tourists' experience, through direct or indirect contact with the site/destination impacts CBBE. Nonetheless, the association between CBX and CBBE is still unclear and evolving in pandemic contexts, hence we suggest:

H5: CBX positively influences CBBE towards a tourism-destination.

The mediating-role of consumer brand experience

As noted, SDL-based CBE refers to a customer's motivationally-based, volitional investments of focal-operant resources (like, emotional, cognitive, behavioural, and social knowledge/skills), and operand-resources (e.g., equipment) in brand interactions (Kumar et al., 2019; Hollebeek et al., 2019b) that we expect to affect CBX, emotional attachment and CBBE. CBE is very critical factor in developing customer satisfaction, increasing loyal consumers, and generating affective connections (Anshu et al., 2022; Arici et al., 2022). Despite this recognition, limited remains acknowledged with respect to engagement and co-creation's potential indirect influence on emotional attachment and CBBE. For instance, published research argued the direct influence of CBE on CBX (Islam et al., 2019; Hollebeek et al., 2014) or exposing CVC's effect on CBX (Prebensen & Xie, 2018; Sugathan & Ranjan, 2019). Correspondingly, customer engagement's affect on their loyalty or CBBE has been further established (Harrigan et al., 2019; Khan et al., 2022).

In other words, although existing literature emphasized the direct association between CBE, CBX, and CVC in the tourism and hospitality industries (Harrigan et al., 2019; Rather et

al., 2019), the indirect link through CBE/CVC is still remains unfamiliar (Arici et al., 2022). Implementation of CBE may be optimized in relationship with CBX (Hollebeek & Rather, 2019), as outlined. Further, Rather et al. (2021) exposed that consumer *intra*-interaction-based engagement expands to their *trans*-interaction-led experience, because it elicits in conjunction with the CBX-journey (e.g., Islam et al., 2019; Jeong & Shin, 2020). We, thus, aim to identify *if* CBE and CVC have an effect on emotional attachment and CBBE through CBX. To respond these queries, we propose:

H6: CBX mediates the relationship with regard to CBE and emotional attachment (H6a); CBE and CBBE (H6b).

H7: CBX mediates the relationship with regard to CVC and emotional attachment (H7a); CVC and CBBE (H7b).

Moderating role of health beliefs - perceived severity and self-efficacy

Derived from cognitive- and affective- frame of behaviour (Rogers, 1975), protection motivation theory or (PMT) aims to assess the health-related behaviour/attitude, and is extensively employed into the tourism/destination research (Cifci et al., 2023; Itani & Hollebeek, 2021; Zhao et al., 2016). PMT-informed perspective recommends that, both threat as well as coping-appraisal elements are fundamental to predict/assess the pandemic/health-related behavioural intents (Liu et al., 2017; Rogers, 1975). The threat appraisal consist of perceived (threat)-severity that states the beliefs concerning seriousness of perceived-threat (Wang et al., 2019). Furthermore, coping-appraisal involves the assessment of health-based protective behaviour responses/intentions to prevent threat, its affects to produce perceived self-efficacy (Zheng et al., 2021). Self-efficacy asserts person's perceived capacity to carry out the recommended behaviours (Bozkurt et al., 2023; Zhao et al., 2016). The threat/coping-appraisals steer person's motivational intents or course-of-actions to protect from perceived threats (Zheng et al., 2021).

Published works substantiated that threat (e.g., perceived pandemic severity) and/or coping (e.g., self efficacy) elements can be dominant variables that persuade customer's attitudes and behaviors in the context of crises (Liu et al., 2017; Prentice et al., 2021; Zheng et al., 2021). We thus examine *if* perceived pandemic severity and perceived self-efficacy can change the tourist's experience/behaviour to elicit emotional attachment and CBBE with a destination.

Since, perceived-severity or self-efficacy moderates the association linking risk perception and (cruise) travel intention (Liu et al., 2017; Zhao et al., 2016) or prediction of tourist activity (Cambra-Fierro et al., 2022b). Hence, we investigate that both health/pandemic-based perceived-severity as well as self-efficacy resulting due to COVID-19 crises moderates the association between CBX/emotional attachment and CBX/CBBE with destinations. Thus, we propose (see also Figure 1):

H8: Self-efficacy moderates the association between CBX and emotional attachment (H8a); CBX and CBBE (H8b).

H9: Perceived severity moderates the association between CBX and emotional attachment (H9a); CBX and CBBE (H9b).

Insert Figure 1 here

Methodology

Measures

We adapted measurement items to evaluate CBX through (Barnes et al., 2014), which includes dimensions of sensory, affective, behavioral and intellectual brand experience (refer also, Brakus et al., 2009). We borrowed CBE scale items via (Hollebeek et al., 2014), which integrates the dimensions of cognitive, affective, and behavioral brand engagement (Rather & Hollebeek, 2021). Further, we assessed value cocreation via (Grissemann & Stokburger-Sauer, 2013), emotional-attachment instrument through (Hang et al., 2020), CBBE from the (Bianchi et al., 2014), and perceived-severity/self-efficacy through (Zhao et al., 2016; Itani & Hollebeek, 2021) measured on 7-Point Likert Scale (refer Appendix A). Before carrying out the ultimate data-collection process, we pre-tested forty respondents to corroborate the scale instrument's content-validity, which advised no issues.

Research design and data collection

In the current research, we employ a questionnaire to gauge the factors summarized in model. We selected Indian tourism destinations (e.g., Gulmargh, Kokernag, Phalgam etc.), as these sites are famous tourist-destination/sites, and where the tourism-industry raises a foremost contribution towards nation's GDP (e.g., Rather, 2020). Moreover, tourism's intrinsically higher

levels of tourist-brand interactions affirm assessment of our model in this ecosystem (So et al., 2020a, b). Third, COVID-19 outbreak has had a global effect on health, economy, business and tourism in India (Statista, 2021), highlighting the further merit of our study.

Our study is cross-sectional in nature, which is a commonly adopted research design in tourism/travel research (Itani & Hollebeek, 2021; Liu et al., 2020; So et al., 2020b; Zheng et al., 2021). We finished the questionnaires in the months of November-December 2021, utilizing convenience-sampling method through self-administrative-survey (Rasoolimanesh et al., 2021). Non-probability-based convenience sampling acts as a vigorous data collection method (Itani & Hollebeek, 2021). To get high-quality data, as per pandemic social distancing rules, the lead author and two experienced research assistants approached respondents while leaving the site/destination at different exit-points (Kumar et al., 2022). Initially, we check out participants by a question: *Are you a tourist in this destination?* The respondents who replied “yes” continued to complete the survey. We requested them to re-call their more recent tourism-based experience/s at any one of preferred sites/destinations. Overall, we disseminated 500 questionnaires, and collected 318, designating 63.5% response-rate. As presented in Table 1, 54% of sample included male, and 46% female participants. Also, In relation to age, 36% of the participants were 18-28 years; 22% were aged 29-39; 41% were 39 years. Table 1 offers the socio-demographic and travel-related information.

Insert Table 1 here

Analysis and results

Testing of measurement model

We utilized partial-least-squares-structural-equation-modeling or (PLS-SEM) to analyze our proposed model in contrast to covariance-based SEM. First, it deals best with complex-models, predictive/exploratory studies and moderating effects (Hair et al., 2018). Second, it is a renowned technique wherein many constructs are investigated simultaneously (e.g., Hair et al., 2018). Third, it is also recognized as a decent methodological-alternative to theory testing (Raza et al., 2021). Further, it is prevalent approach used in tourism/destination studies (Abbasi et al., 2022a, b).

Table 2 revealed constructs' reliability as well as validity of measurement-model. Table 2 indicated standardized path-loadings extended from 0.765 to 0.936, thereby, exhibiting satisfactory convergent validity levels (i.e., > 0.70). Likewise, Cronbach's alpha and composite reliability (CR) values exceeding the cutoff point 0.70, while average variance extracted (AVE) surpassing 0.50, advocating also agreeable reliability and convergent-validity (Hair et al., 2018). Also, variance-inflation-factors (VIF) were estimated (Table, 2), which denotes that common-method-bias not exists in our study, because their values were below 5 (Kock, 2015). Relatedly, Harman's single-test illustrated the similar results, explained 36.7% of variance (less than cut-off value of 50%; Podsakoff et al., 2003).

Insert Table 2 here

The Fornell and Larcker (1981) principle was used to assess discriminant validity. As indicated in Table 3, square-root of AVE-values for each factor surpassed bivariate correlations, among these factors, corroborating the affirmation of discriminant validity.

Insert Table-3 here

Testing of structural model

All modeled associations were supported, and the path-coefficients revealed positive- effects amongst latent factors. First, we found the positive-effect of CBE on CBX, thus supports H1 ($\beta = 0.631, p < 0.01$). Correspondingly, we found significant/positive evidence in the link between CBE and CVC ($\beta = 0.582, p < 0.01$), thus supports H2. That's why, this study provides full support to H1 and H2 suggest that CBE drives CBX and CVC during pandemic. In addition, CVC have a significant/positive- influence on CBX ($\beta = 0.597, p < 0.01$), thus supports H3. Further, H4-H5, which envisages that CBX elicits emotional attachment ($\beta = 0.618, p < 0.01$) as well as CBBE ($\beta = 0.624, p < 0.01$) were supported also (Table 4).

Next, we assessed predictive relevancy (Q^2) and explanatory power (R^2) of our outcome variables, which surpassed the upper-limit 0.10 (Falk & Miller, 1992; Henseler et al., 2016) that proves the good enough predictive-model relevance (Table 4). Moreover, we assessed Cohen's (1988) effect-size (f^2) of our main predictors. The values of f^2 extended from (0.06 - 0.37) reflecting weak- to stronger- effects (Table 4).

Insert Table 4 here

Mediation and moderation effects

To check mediation effects, we utilized PROCESS with 5000 bootstrapping resamples procedure at 95% confidence intervals (CI) (Preacher & Hayes, 2008), as this approach has been extensively adopted in tourism (Rather et al., 2021; Wu et al., 2021). In mediation models, bootstrapping offers important analysis to understand the indirect effects (Hayes, 2013). The confidence intervals meant for the indirect effects did not encompass zero, indicating that mediation was supported in favor of H6a-H7b (Table 5). CBE established an indirect influence on EA through CBX ($\beta = 0.34$, 95% CI [0.14, 0.25]). Besides, the direct impact of CBE and EA was statistically significant, implying partial-mediation and supported H6a. Overall, results propose that CBE indirectly boosts emotional attachment and CBBE by improving CBX during COVID-19 epidemic (see, Table 5).

Insert Table 5 here

Lastly, in our structural model, the moderating effect of health belief-based *self-efficacy* and *perceived pandemic severity* in hypothesized causal relationships linking CBX and EA; and CBX and CBBE was estimated adopting Fassott et al.'s (2016) two-stage PLS-method. Firstly, we ran PLS path model for main-effects to attain construct scores of in-dependent (X), and moderator (M) factors. Second, we develop interaction-term (X.M), as an element-wise product of construct (structure) scores of X and M (Fassott et al., 2016). As a result, we found a significant- and negative moderating interaction effect of pandemic-based *perceived severity* on emotional attachment ($\beta = -0.261$, $p < 0.01$), and CBBE ($\beta = -0.285$, $p < 0.01$), thereby confirming H8a/b. However, we established a significant positive moderating interaction effect of *self-efficacy* on emotional attachment ($\beta = 0.267$, $p < 0.01$), and CBBE ($\beta = 0.322$, $p < 0.01$), thus, substantiating H9a/b (Table 6).

Insert Table 6 here

Discussion and conclusion

The present research investigated the dynamics of consumer brand engagement on consumer-value co-creation and consumer brand experience, and its consequent impact on their emotional

attachment and CBBE, by evaluating a structural model via PLS-SEM. The typical pandemic context of our study provides more insights in the modeled associations amongst these important factors beyond many of the existing research (Kabadayi et al., 2022; Kumar et al., 2022; Park & Gong, 2023; Shoukat & Ramkissoon, 2022; So et al., 2021). Particularly, such novel findings on pandemics effecting tourist's engagement, experience, or behaviour prepares destination marketers to effectively manage enduring effects of COVID-19 outbreak, including after global-pandemic, by learning from past crises/outbreaks (Zheng et al., 2021).

This research also procures a broad glance at consumer journey in tourism-destination and resulting variables that impact the (post)-consumption behaviors (e.g., CBBE). Particularly, the proposed SDL-framework offers a theoretical foundation to evaluate how CBE affects tourists' value co-creation and experience. Thus, this experience also impacts subsequent (post)-consumption behaviors (i.e., attachment and CBBE) during pandemic. Existing research has investigated the impact of media engagement and health (protective) behavior on global pandemic tourism (Cambra-Fierro et al., 2022b; Rather, 2022), although, interface of CBE, CVC, CBX, attachment, CBBE, and perceived health beliefs has remained un-explored.

As further corroborated in this research, CBX significantly affects emotional attachment and CBBE. We thus expands existing literature on the association between CBX, attachment and CBBE in the field of psychology (Bowlby, 1979) by verifying and discussing the association between CBX and tourists emotional attachment and CBBE into a particular field of service marketing (i.e., tourism/destination). The findings are in agreement with the contemporary knowledge in tourism/destination service research which advocates that visitors who have positive/pleasant experience towards a destination/brand are more expected to yield strong emotional attachments/bonds with that site/brand (Verhoef et al., 2009; Liu et al., 2020) as well as build increased brand equity with the destination (Bianchi et al., 2014). Although, as research on CBBE is burgeoning in tourism/destination context; Rahman et al., 2020; Sürücü et al., 2019), it might be important for future studies to explore its dimensions/aspects (e.g., brand-loyalty, awareness perceived quality; Algharabat et al., 2020) within the destination/brand context. This will assist to provide more insight of CBX on respective CBBE's aspects.

Further, mediating role of CBX on emotional attachment and CBBE through CBE and CVC follows existing studies (Arici et al., 2022; Khan et al., 2022; Prebensen & Xie, 2018;

Jeong & Shin, 2020), sustaining the significance of generating pleasant and positive-experiences to encourage tourist's emotional attachment and CBBE. CBX, as an extensive evaluation of a consumer journey (Lemon & Verhoef, 2017; Shoukat & Ramkissoon, 2022) effects tourist's emotional attachment and consumer based brand equity. Eventually, while enhanced significance need be put on consumer's based brand equity, the online (social) media and broad social-networks, once it comes to generation of positive- (or negative) experiences, the crucial focus remains the engagement and value co-creation with a destination during pandemic.

To conclude, while moderating role of pandemic-based perceived severity/self-efficacy are essential into the effect of CBE on attachment and CBBE, represents critical managerial insights. During the pandemic, decay in travel and tourist's intentions typically occurs from their perceived risk/severity to become infected or due to long-term travel restrictions (Ren et al., 2022). Given that existing literature view perceived severity/self-efficacy as drivers of particular proposed associations (Itani & Hollebeek, 2021; Liu et al., 2017; Prentice et al., 2021), this study envisaged the strength of investigated associations, which would fluctuate among visitors displaying unique threat or coping appraisal-levels.

Theoretical implications

The present study generates the following contributions to marketing, tourism, and branding literature. The COVID-19 crises has considerably effected consumers consumption behaviors and engagement (UNWTO, 2022), producing new challenges for tourism-destination marketers. To limit these challenges, tourism-marketers are increasingly employing consumer-brand relationship strategies (Algharabat et al., 2020; Kabadayi et al., 2022; Miao et al., 2022; Wongsansukcharoen, 2021). Thus, we developed and tested a proposed conceptual model, which integrates customer's brand engagement, value co-creation, experience, emotional attachment and CBBE during pandemic-based tourism context. Given the enclosure of such variables on *research priorities* of Marketing Science Institutes (2020), the progress of additional knowledge of these concepts and their link into COVID-19 outbreak exposes an imperative development in marketing (service tourism/destination) research, as delineated. This research thereby contributes to theoretical comprehension of these concepts in tourism/destination and service brand context.

Second theoretical contribution is to examine the CBX's effect on tourist's emotional attachment and CBBE, which revealed that CBX employs a positive impact on their emotional attachment/CBBE towards destinations/sites during the pandemic. This finding adds to a better knowledge of the drivers of CBX/brand equity, which can contribute in eliciting the tourism-CBBE and attaining increased competitiveness among tourist-destinations/sites during COVID-19 times. Thus, robust site/destination-powered CBX yields tourists more productive assessment in improving relationship and psychological connection with a service destination brand (Kumar et al., 2022; Shoukat & Ramkissoon, 2022; Wongsansukcharoen, 2021). Particularly, tourists were recognized to be primarily driven through CBX in eliciting their emotional attachment and consumer-based brand equity with the destination in pandemic times.

The third theoretical contribution has been related to CBX's mediating effect. While extant works confirmed a direct influence of CBE on CBX or CBBE (Iglesias et al., 2020; Islam et al., 2019), the empirically-led examination in the association of our modeled factors remained limited to date; Shoukat & Ramkissoon, 2022; MSI, 2020), especially in tourism/destination and service marketing-based pandemic environment. The aforesaid finding in proportion to previous research (Harrigan et al., 2019; Jeong & Shin, 2020), however also produces a novel contribution to the SDL perspective. In other words, we contribute to marketing/tourism and SDL-literature by improving insights about CBE/CBBE development process, which is especially relevant and needs more scholastic attention in tourism-destination literature.

The finally theoretical contribution of this research is to provide increased insight in the moderating role of perceived health beliefs- (perceived self-efficacy and pandemic severity) into the projected relationships. Owing to our attain insight, PMT-informed lens offers an important theoretical framework to update COVID-19 pandemic research (Han et al., 2022), therefore, informing various future research possibilities. Such as: How does the estimated modeled links, like moderating role of pandemic/health-based factors on visitor's prevention behavior during/post-outbreak (Prentice et al., 2021; Ren et al., 2022), as described also in last section.

Managerial implications

This research further outlines implications for marketing and tourism practitioners and managers. Firstly, the study's findings encourage the implementation of CBE in mix with CBX/CBBE

tactics to produce supreme outcomes during outbreak (Hollebeek et al., 2021b; Miao et al., 2022). Accordingly, we advocate destination managers to elicit visitors' (*intra*)-interaction as a strategic opportunity to increase their (*trans*)-interaction CBX journey (Jeong & Shin, 2020; Shoukat & Ramkissoon, 2022). Hence, (*intra*)-interaction engagement acts as an influential building block for experience.

Second, tourism-destination marketers can consider in eliciting CBE towards a particular destination/brand to obtain a competitive benefit over their industry rivals (Kumar et al., 2022; So et al., 2021). Destination-brand marketers and DMOs may require to focus on CBE at tourist-destinations/sites, and need to extend stakeholder involvement in tourism planning process (Rather, 2022), comprising small travel agencies or local-community. This can assist destinations marketers to change their focus from goods-dominant logic to SDL and thereby enhance CBE-based value co-creation and experience (Park & Vargo, 2013; Blazquez-Resino et al., 2016). Consequently, CBE with destination-brands facilitates them to offer suggestions about uprising value to service-delivery process, advices concerning the current level of services, complements, complaints, and recommendations for generating more emotional/cognitive brand experiences.

Third, to nurture CBE-based value co-creation and CBX, we advocate tourism marketers to foster tourist resource investment/s in their destination (brand) interactions. Such as, to integrate customized services, high interactive offerings (e.g., personalized tour/visit packages, visitor's educational-programs; Kumar et al., 2022; Rather & Hollebeek, 2021; So et al., 2021). Artificial-intelligence, augmented/virtual reality-powered interaction/s might be used to foretell visitor's needs, desires, or preferences in COVID-19 crises; Li et al., 2022). Further, marketers should assess consumers' activities/actions into particular platforms to support favorable brand content. This content may highlight or imparting social actions (i.e., user-generated content), hedonic activities (i.e., recreational, leisure, entertaining), or informational benefits (i.e., historic, cultural, heritage) (Anshu et al., 2022). Further, tourism-brands' contents with utmost applicability to its potential consumers (by content-marketing) is tend to facilitate the improvement of destination/brand connection/equity (e.g., Indian slogan: *Incredible India* or Taiwan's: *The heart of Asia* slogan displays meaning, warmth, value, love; Aro et al., 2018), thus, eliciting tourist's CBBE and emotional attachment towards an attraction/destination.

Fourth, new/potential visitors look for more engaging, memorable, compelling, and robust experiences (Pine & Gilmore, 1999; Homburg et al., 2016; Lemon & Verhoef, 2017). Our integrative conceptual framework strengthens this idea by stressing on CBX, which (marketing) destination managers can adopt to engage visitors and increase attachment and consumer-based brand equity (Berry, 2000; Pansari & Kumar 2017). Thus, destination marketers, DMOs, and policymakers can develop historical and cultural heritage whereas preserving natural attractions (Rahman et al., 2020). Tourism marketing managers can also ponder destination awareness campaigns and heritage-protection-schemes to conserve destinations/sites in fostering visitors' memorable brand experiences, attachment, or brand equity (Rather & Hollebeek, 2021).

Finally, findings verify the moderation impacts of pandemic/health belief-based self-efficacy/perceived-severity initiated by COVID-19, thus, policy makers and tourism managers should give importance in their marketing and tourism tactics, communicating perceived-risk reduction strategies, or strategic responses to reinforce CBX, which in turn elicits emotional attachment and consumer-based brand equity during the recent global-outbreak (Han et al., 2022; Ren et al., 2022).

Limitations and scope for future research

Nonetheless, this paper contributes to tourism/destination marketing knowledge; it also proffers several limitations for potential analysis. Firstly, this research was conducted in Indian context, future studies would expand the data-collection process (e.g., Australia, Africa, Europe), and analyze the proposed-model in other nations and cultures, to attain an additional general results. Second, this work was based on cross-sectional research design, implying that survey-data was gathered at one specified period. Accordingly, future research can adopt longitudinal study to provide more generalisable results.

Third, while we explore the role of only two direct consequences of CBE (CVC/CBX), thus, future study may scrutinize other consequences of consumer brand engagement including brand trust, satisfaction, positive/negative word-of-mouth, commitment, identification and/or image to spawn extra knowledge (Bahri et al., 2021; Do & Bowden, 2023; Parrey et al., 2020; Rather & Camilleri, 2019; Shams et al., 2020).

Fourth, we examine two antecedents of CBX (e.g., CBE/CVC), future research may wish to include antecedents of CBX like relationship marketing orientation, consumer participation, consumer involvement or self-expressive brand (Algharabat et al., 2020; Kabadayi et al., 2022; Rather, 2018). Fifth, we examine two important outcomes of CBX (emotional attachment and CBBE). Thus, other variables might be adopted such as, brand love and brand loyalty (Rather et al., 2022a,b) and/or travel avoidance (Zheng et al., 2021) that can create supplementary insights.

Sixth, we inspect moderating impact of pandemic-based self-efficacy/perceived severity; further research would consider other moderating effects, like tourist's age, gender in probing CBE, CVC and CBX associations (Kautish et al., 2021). Finally, future research would also investigate the role of mobile, social media technologies, metaverse-based virtual or augmented reality in evolving sustainable consumer engagement, experience, and social business (Abbasi et al., 2023; Hollebeek et al., 2022; Vo-Thanh et al., 2021; Wongsansukcharoen, 2021).

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